

MLP 2026 Strength of Record — Through Event 4 (Austin)

As of June 14, 2026 · Internal analysis · Not official MLP data

WHAT IS STRENGTH OF RECORD?

Strength of Record (SOR) measures how *impressive* a team's results have been relative to the quality of the opponents involved. It answers a question that raw standings don't: **did you beat good teams, and did you only lose to good teams?**

Key insight: Two teams can have the same event placement but very different SOR. Finishing 2nd by losing only to the highest-rated team in the field is more impressive than finishing 2nd by barely surviving a weak field.

HOW IT'S CALCULATED

Each team is assigned an average roster quality score using **DUPR** (Dynamic Universal Pickleball Rating), the official MLP player rating system. Doubles DUPR runs roughly 5.0 (recreational) to 7.5+ (world-class pro). The six-player roster average is used as each team's quality proxy.

For each event a team plays, we compute a **per-event SOR contribution**:

$$\text{SOR contribution} = (\text{sum of beaten teams' avg DUPR} + \text{sum of loss penalties}) \div (\text{field size} - 1)$$

Where the loss penalty for each team that beat you is:

$$(\text{that team's avg DUPR}) - (\text{highest avg DUPR in the event field})$$

This means: - **Beating a strong team** contributes more than beating a weak team. - **Losing to the best team in the field** costs nearly zero. - **Losing to a weak team** costs significantly more.

A team's final SOR is the average of its per-event contributions across all events played.

Placement tiers: MLP does not publish full head-to-head results for every match. Where exact sub-placings are unknown, teams are grouped into a "tied tier" and contribute zero SOR credit to each other. This is conservative — it avoids fabricating wins or losses.

CURRENT STANDINGS

Rank	Team	Avg DUPR	Events Played	SOR
1	Los Angeles Mad Drops	6.180	2	+5.74
2	New Jersey 5s	6.343	3	+5.59
3	St. Louis Shock	6.212	3	+5.19

Rank	Team	Avg DUPR	Events Played	SOR
4	Columbus Sliders	6.177	3	+5.18
5	Brooklyn Pickleball Team †	6.274	1	+4.78
6	Palm Beach Royals	6.030	2	+3.84
7	Las Vegas Night Owls ‡	5.813	2	+3.23
8	Texas Ranchers	5.929	2	+2.35
9	SoCal Hard Eights	5.849	2	+2.28
10	Orlando Squeeze	6.150	2	+2.06
11	Miami Pickleball Club ‡	6.014	2	+1.67
12	Atlanta Bouncers ‡	6.149	3	+1.44
13	Bay Area Breakers ‡	6.000	3	+1.28
14	Utah Black Diamonds ‡	5.975	2	+1.13
15	Florida Smash ‡	5.917	2	+0.15
16	California Black Bears ‡	5.833	2	+0.15
17	Carolina Hogs	5.829	3	+0.09
18	Phoenix Flames ‡	5.950	2	-0.13
19	Chicago Slice ‡	5.999	1	-0.13
20	Dallas Flash	6.090	2	-0.19

† **Small sample** (1 event played — treat with caution) ‡ **All DUPR values estimated** — see below

WHERE ESTIMATES ARE MADE

Player DUPR Ratings

DUPR.com blocks direct access, so values were sourced from PickleWave profiles, Electrum Pickleball athlete pages, and continental rankings. We now have **confirmed DUPR values for ~55+ players**, including full rosters for NJ 5s, St. Louis Shock, LA Mad Drops, Brooklyn, and Texas Ranchers.

Teams with fully confirmed rosters (no estimates): NJ 5s, St. Louis Shock, LA Mad Drops, Brooklyn Pickleball Team, Texas Ranchers.

Teams with mostly confirmed rosters (1–2 players estimated): Columbus Sliders, Dallas Flash, SoCal Hard Eights, Carolina Hogs, Atlanta Bouncers, Chicago Slice, Las Vegas Night Owls, Orlando Squeeze, Miami, Palm Beach Royals, Utah Black Diamonds.

Teams with all-estimated rosters (marked ‡): Bay Area Breakers, California Black Bears, Florida Smash, Phoenix Flames.

Two values to note: Elsie Hendershot's DUPR (5.124) is confirmed from Sep 2025 and may have since risen; JW Johnson's value was updated to 7.021 (May 2026 source) from a previously cited 7.17.

Event Placements

MLP publishes final standings but not always the detailed sub-placings within the lower half of the field. The following positions are grouped as "tied" in our model:

Event	Tied Positions	Teams Affected
Dallas	5th–11th	Bay Area, Carolina Hogs, Dallas Flash, Orlando, Phoenix, Texas Ranchers, Utah
Columbus	7th–11th	CA Black Bears, Chicago Slice, Miami, Carolina Hogs, Florida Smash
St. Louis	8th–9th	Bay Area Breakers & Atlanta Bouncers (order unknown)
Austin	7th–10th	Atlanta Bouncers, Carolina Hogs, CA Black Bears, Florida Smash

WHAT WE'D NEED TO MAKE THIS FULLY ACCURATE

- 1. Confirmed DUPR for all roster players** — the single biggest driver of accuracy. With ~57 estimated DUPRs, the DUPR quality proxy can be off by 0.2–0.5 points for many teams, which cascades into SOR errors. Direct DUPR.com access (or manual lookup) for all ~120 players on 20 rosters would resolve this.
- 2. Exact placements for all tied-tier positions** — particularly the Dallas 5–11 bucket (7 teams lumped together). Getting the actual 5th–11th place order for Dallas would unlock meaningful SOR signal for roughly half the league.
- 3. Pool play results within each event** — currently we use only final Super Sunday standings. If pool play records were available (who beat whom during the group stage), we could weight head-to-head results directly rather than inferring from final placement tiers.
- 4. Trade/roster confirmation for several teams** — Columbus's acquired player (return for Danni-Elle Townsend), Miami's full roster beyond Dylan Frazier, and several teams listed with placeholder "Player 2/3/etc." entries.

Analysis produced using `pickleball/mlp_sor.py`. Events: Dallas (5/25), Columbus (5/31), St. Louis (6/7), Austin (6/14). Five events remain in the 2026 regular season.